

Introduction

The foreign policy of India has changed greatly in the post-cold war period, due to the changes in world powers, the globalization of economies and the security situation in the region. In the early 1990s, India began with the Look East Policy whose main focus was to consolidate economic and diplomatic ties with the Southeast Asian countries upon economic liberalisation. This policy became a strategic break with the previous inward looking and non-aligned policy of India that signified the appreciation of East and Southeast Asia as important zones to the economic growth and geopolitical concern of India. Nonetheless, the Look East Policy was engagement-based and was commonly criticised as lacking strategy and implemented slowly (Ministry of External Affairs, 2014).

In 2014, Prime Minister Narendra Modi changed the policy of the Look East Policy to the Act East Policy which marked a qualitative change in the foreign policy of India. The Act East Policy ulcerated the importance of not only economic cooperation with the East and Southeast Asia but also strategic, defense and security relationships. The Act term was indicative of an effort to be more proactive in diplomacy, to act faster, and to focus more on practical results. This change was accompanied by the increasing desire of India to become a more dominant player in the regional and international politics, especially in the Indo-Pacific area.

Simultaneously with this trend in establishing diplomacy, the maritime sphere has become one of the key points in the Indian strategic thought. Being one of the Peninsulaic states with a long coastline and being a strategic location in the Indian Ocean, the maritime Stability of India is highly related to its security and economic interests. Sea lines of communication are considered to be a key interest to the nation as more than 90 per cent of national trade is by volume via the sea. As a result, maritime strategy has also been considered as a critical tool towards the fostering of India foreign policy goals, including those that are defined under the Act East Policy. The maritime policy of India has been experiencing a sharp orientation since the liberalization of the economy in 1991. The initial Look East Policy (LEP) aimed at capitalizing on economic integration with the ASEAN region and reinstate India relations with the East and South East Asian neighborhood. Over time, especially since 2014 under the Act East Policy (AEP), the focus was no longer on outreach but actually implemented: connectivity, maritime infrastructure, Indo-Pacific strategic presence, and naval and institutional partnerships came into the limelight. In that regard, maritime policy shifts to be less peripheral to the continental, land-based vision of India and attains a more similar land-sea orientation, with coastal security, the blue economy, port-led development (as embodied in the Sagarmala programme), and naval alliances becoming the pivot of the trade, the supply chains, and the influence.

Rationale

The purpose of this research is that although much literature is available on continental security issues in India namely the border issues and the sub-continental geopolitics, no detailed synthesis exists that enables the correlation of the development of the maritime policy in India between the Look East period and the Act East period in relation to policy documents, the development of the naval doctrine, regional organizations, the connectivity/infrastructure programmes and the maritime strategy. Specifically, the maritime aspect of the Indian foreign policy includes several strings economic, infrastructural, institutional, and military ones that have so far been viewed in isolation. Combining these strands, this paper explains how the objectives, instruments and alliances of India in the maritime domain have failed and developed over time and the connotations this has on the sustainability and consistency of the Indian maritime strategy in the future.

Context of the study

The 2014-2025 era is a crucial window in the repositioning of India strategically in Asia. This decade, India aimed to re-establish its place in the regional order, through the further involvement in the ASEAN, more active contact with the main partners, Japan, Australia, and the United States, and extending its influence into the greater Indo-Pacific. The mentioning of the Indo-Pacific as a strategic construct was an acknowledgement of the interdependence between the Indian and Pacific oceans by India and the necessity of a holistic approach to the region (Integrated Headquarters, Ministry of Defence Navy, 2015).

The development of China and the escalation of tools and tactics in the Indo-Pacific has been a characteristic of this period. The rising naval presence of China, the broadening of the Belt and Road Initiative, and the increasing operations in the Indian Ocean have been causing a rise in the security concerns in the region. India has responded by focusing on cooperation on maritime security and freedom of navigation and international law of the sea. The involvement in the multilateral formations including the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (QUAD) and the Security and Growth for All in the Region (SAGAR) doctrine are some of the initiatives that highlight the changing maritime and strategic concerns of India.

The maritime security, trade routes and the naval diplomacy has thus become significant means of the external engagement by India. The strongest connections have been built through naval drills, port visits, capacity-building operations and humanitarian aid and disaster recovery

(HADR) operations to position India as a responsible regional player. These developments present a significant contextual background to the understanding of the context of the relationship between the Act East Policy and maritime strategy of India (ASEAN-India Summit Secretariat, 2024).

Historical Evolution

Liberalization and Look East Phase I (1991–2003)

- Economic reform and outreach to the ASEAN based on trade.
- The first naval diplomacy and drills (the formation of MALABAR, bilateral/ASEAN interactions).
- New concepts of IOR in post-Cold War after 1991.

Look East Phase II (2003–2014)

- Deepening ties with ASEAN (FTA milestones), East Asia Summits participation.
- Naval doctrine evolution post-2004 tsunami.
- Maritime boundary settlement with Bangladesh culminating in 2014.

Act East and the Indo-Pacific (2014–2024)

- Act East Policy enacted.
- SAGAR (Security and Growth for All in the Region).
- IPOI (2019) pillars
- QUAD revival and functional working groups.
- Infrastructure projects
- Sagarmala, inland–coastal integration, maritime clusters.

Coastal security enhancement.

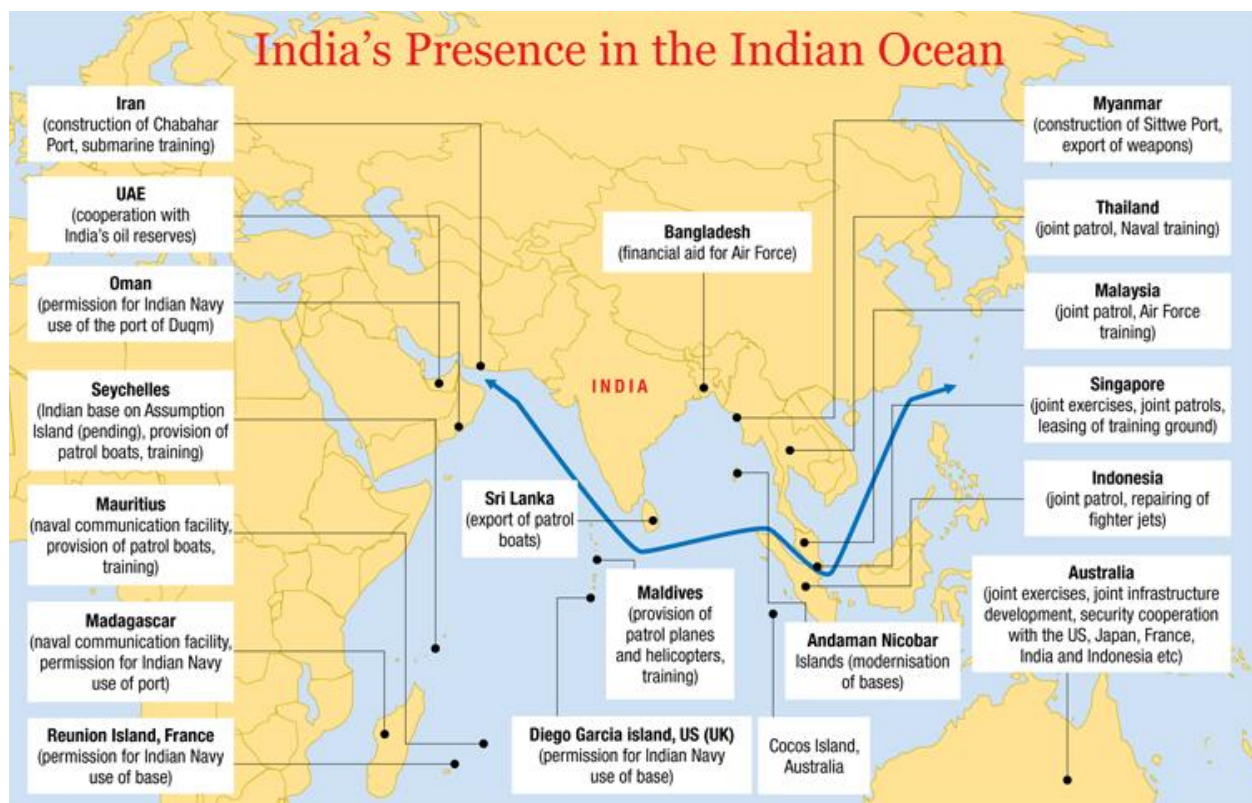
Table 1: Comparative Overview of LEP vs AEP (Maritime-Focus)

Dimension	Look East Policy (1991-2014)	Act East Policy (2014-2024)
Core Objective	Economic engagement with ASEAN; revive regional linkages	Strategic outreach in Indo-Pacific; maritime infrastructure and security partnerships
Primary Instruments	Dialogue/FTA with ASEAN, trade, cultural-linkages	Connectivity (ports, corridors), blue-economy, naval partnerships, institutional engagement (QUAD, IPOI)
Maritime Orientation	Emerging: recognition of coast, ports, India-ASEAN maritime links	Mature: strong maritime security posture, port-led development (Sagarmala), deep institutional engagement
Partnership Geographies	Bay of Bengal/ASEAN focus	Expanded: Bay of Bengal + Western Pacific + Indian Ocean Region (IOR)
Drivers	Economic liberalisation, ASEAN growth	China's maritime rise, Indo-Pacific geopolitics, supply-chain logic, climate/sea-risks
Institutional/Ecosystem Evolution	ASEAN Dialogue Partner, some naval links	Broader institutional architecture (IORA, IONS), deep naval/strategic ties with US/Japan/Australia, robust connectivity projects

Literature Review

Conceptualizing India's Maritime resurgence

The recent literature on the maritime policy of India associates the revival after 1991 to both structural and domestic factors. Early Look East literature is maritime engagement placed in the context of the larger process of economic liberalization and regional integration. This, according to Acharya (2014) and Mohan (2003), was a result of liberalization which created an extroverted model of growth that pursued markets and investment in ASEAN which pushed India out to sea in trade and energy corridors. This economic rationality is superimposed by the classical maritime theory by strategists. Brewster (2014) and Holmes and Yoshihara (2008) implement Mahanian ideas of sea power and find the strategic geography of India in the nexus of the Arabian Sea, Bay of Bengal, and Malacca. Sea geography then forms a basis of the equilibrium between the land and sea needs.



Source; <https://www.insightsonindia.com/2021/08/09/insights-into-editorial-an-opportunity-for-india-to-pitch-for-holistic-maritime-security/>

Regional and strategic context: the IOR region

The discourse on the Indian Ocean Region (IOR) highlights the increased tension in the extraregional navies and geopolitical emergence of the Chinese Maritime Silk Road (BRI). Chaudhuri (2018) and Khurana (2008) present the IOR as a security complex, in which the geographical centrality of India can be seen as both the opportunity and vulnerability. Brewster (2012) builds on this perception by examining how the maritime diplomacy and the naval presence of India is responding to Chinese dual-use port projects otherwise known as the String of Pearls.

Similarly, parallel studies are done on the changing navy doctrine and modernization of India. India became an operationally oriented sea power in 2007 with the update of its doctrine and in 2015 with its seminal Ensuring Secure Seas: Indian Maritime Security Strategy (2015) (Indian Navy, 2015). Scott (2012) and Pant and Supaat (2015) view such doctrines as the Indian effort to balance the goals of seawater control and sea-denial, and institutionalize Maritime Domain Awareness (MDA) and Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief (HADR) missions.

Maritime Governance and Post-26/11 Reforms

The terror attacks which occurred in Mumbai in the year 2008 prompted a significant reorganisation of the Indian coast security structure. Information Gill (2019) and National Maritime Foundation (NMF) issue briefs explain the creation of a National Command, Control, Communication and Intelligence (NC3I) network and the creation of the Information Management and Analysis Centre (IMAC) in Gurugram, later added by the Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region (IFC-IOR) in 2018. These programs formalized the MDA, including the naval, coast-guard, and state-level actors.

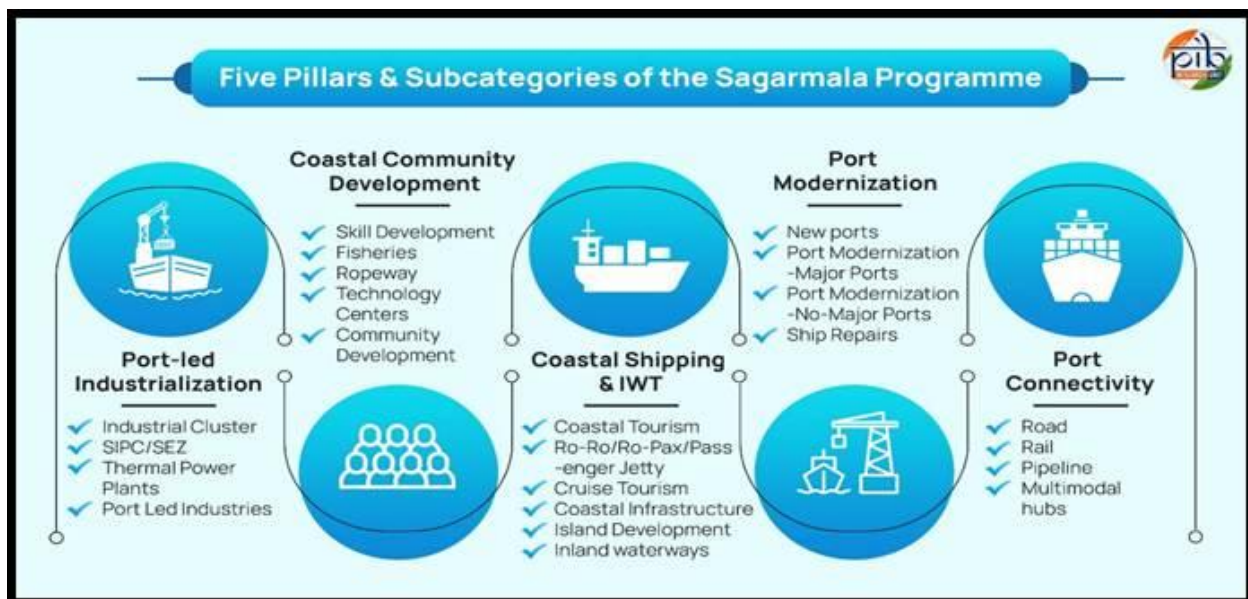
Although these measures have already introduced a step-change in the governance, multiple authors report that inter-agencies coordination issues continue to persist and that the implementation across the coastal states remains uneven (Gill, 2019; Rehman, 2020). Literature therefore makes post-26/11 reforms a technological and a bureaucratic change - the incorporation of the maritime governance into the Indian internal security landscape.

Economic strategy : port led development and Blue Economy

The resurrection of the maritime India also has a logistics and development agenda. The white papers of the government like the Sagarmala Programme Report (Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways [MoPSW], 2020) and Maritime India Vision 2030 (MoPSW, 2021) have put port modernization in line with trade facilitation, industrial corridors, and blue-economy ambitions. Gupta (2020) and NITI Aayog (2021) also point to the efficiency improvement with the implementation of multimodal connectivity, yet they note that some gaps in implementation and the lack of centrality and fragmentation of agencies in the central and state tiers.

To discuss this topic in terms of sustainability, blue-economy literature (Chandra and Ghosh, 2019) goes further: the development of infrastructure change and the environment of coastal livelihoods, marine biodiversity, and spatial planning. This signifies an epistemic change of ports as a trade gateway to sustainable growth nodes.

Figure 2.2: Sagarmala and Blue-Economy Linkages showing port clusters, industrial corridors, and environmental zones



Source: <https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2115878®=3&lang=2>

Regionalism and the Indo-Pacific orientation

Since 2014, India has shifted to an ASEAN-based regionalism to a broader Indo-Pacific model by changing its approach of Look East to Act East. As Sato (2019) notes, the AEP incorporates

ASEAN centrality and involves more minilateral coalitions such as the Quad (US-Japan-Australia-India). Jaishankar (2020) places this turn within a practical doctrine of strategic autonomy plus alliances, according to which India picks and chooses on matters of maritime politics without alliances.

Medcalf (2020) takes this to be an Indo-Pacific mental maps - linking the Western Pacific to the Eastern Indian Ocean via rule-based order and open sea-lanes. This vision is operationalized by the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI) (2019) using the following cooperative pillars, namely: maritime security, marine resources, capacity building, and disaster risk reduction.

Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief (HADR)

Empirical evidence of the expanding operational reach of India has been given in case studies of the operations of HADR. Brewster (2012) describes the 2004 Indian Ocean Tsunami as a turning point when India put its naval forces at work to provide relief to the region and this triggered its image as a net security provider. Gopalakrishnan (2021) provides this discussion with further operations, Nepal 2015, and COVID-19 maritime logistics to show that India is capable of integrating soft-power diplomatic strategies with hard-power logistics. HADR therefore becomes a workable and image dimension of the Indian maritime policy.

Legal and Diplomatic Frameworks

Regardless of the rich accounts about the Indian maritime outreach and the move towards a maritime orientation, there is still a gap: there is still a lack of a comprehensive synthesis of the way the Indian maritime policy changed since the period of the Look East (1991-2014) up to the period of Act East (2014-2024). In particular, the transformation of the goals (economic vs strategic), tools (connectivity, ports, naval presence), and alliances (bilateral, multilateral, regional institutions) between the two epochs is dispersed among various research and government publications but does not have a common analytical approach. The proposed research is the first to fulfill this gap by tracking and connecting the change of Indian maritime policy, tracing the routes through the institutional frameworks, evaluating the role of outside influences (including maritime expansion by China, MSR/BRI, piracy, HADR and climate risk) and inside forces

(including the development of the coastal security apparatus, the awareness of the maritime domain, and port-led development) in shaping the results.

Critical and realist approaches bring in caution. According to Tellis (2017), the gap exists between the capability and commitment, where the rhetoric on the topic of India is faster than its naval capabilities. Shipbuilding slurs, financial shortfall, and manpower constraint frustrates quick achievement of maritime dreams. Rehman (2020) urges the jointness by proposing a Maritime Theatre Command because inter-service fragmentation contributes to weakening the deterrence pose of India.

Strategic Alignment between Act East Policy and India's Maritime Strategy

Bajpae (2023) demonstrated that the strategic congruency of the Act East Policy (AEP) and the maritime strategy in India has become a highly significant field of academic discussion, especially regarding the changing geopolitics in the Indo-Pacific. It is becoming more apparent in the available literature that maritime power is emerging as a potent tool which India aims to use to make operational its larger foreign policy goals under the Act East process. The focus of AEP on closer links with East and Southeast Asia, according to scholars, cannot be successfully implemented without plausible maritime capacity due to the focus of the sea lines of communications, regional trade routes and maritime security in the Indo-Pacific region.

Some of the studies point out that the Indian maritime diplomacy, collaborative maritime activities and visiting ports of ASEAN and other East Asian nations are practical extensions of the AEP diplomatic objectives. Multilateral naval drills, defence alliances, supporting regional littoral states through capacity building have often been mentioned as indications of a greater alignment between policy select and practice. Such operations increase the strategic visibility of India and build confidence with the regional partners and its image as a responsible security provider

Nonetheless, there are also significant shortcomings of full strategic alignment that are described in the literature. There are resource shortages, lapses in the development of naval capacity, and the difficulty of coordinating institutions between diplomatic and defence establishments, among analysts. In addition, this disposition of strategic autonomy in India has even led to uncertainty in its maritime signalling that influences the uniformity of policy

implementation. In its turn, this prompts researchers to believe that a general correspondence between the goals of Act East and the idea of maritime strategy can be discussed but it is still incomplete and developing. This knowledge gap in an integrated analysis indicates that it is necessary to conduct a qualitative study that will determine the effectiveness with which maritime strategy can turn the ambitions of Act East into long-term strategic deliverables.

Critical Perspectives and Capability Constraints

There is also an academic debate over which priorities should have taken precedence between the continental ones and the maritime ones. The security apparatus of India is still based on contingencies of the land-border, restricting the allocation of maritime resources (Scott, 2012; Tellis, 2017). However, these writers are united on the idea that the maritime vehicle is irreversible; it is a question of time, order, and risk control and not orientation.

Gaps in literature

In the fields of political economy, strategic studies, international law and environmental policy a general agreement is found that India is experiencing a long-term maritime turn. However, in the literature, there is disagreement on three analytical levels:

1. **Rapidity of Change:** The optimists emphasize increased engagement pace with AEP, the sceptics observe bureaucratic inertia and capacity lags.
2. **Prioritization:** There are still some arguments as to whether economic connectivity or strategic deterrence is the driving force behind policy. There are those who consider Sagarmala as developmental and there are those who consider Sagarmala as dual-use
3. **Risk Management:** There is inconsistency in the capability of India to deal with the geopolitical and climatic risks in expansive water bodies.

Research Problem

Although both the Act East Policy and the maritime strategy have become increasingly important as part of the foreign policy of India, the available scholarly literature tends to believe in considering the two areas independently. The diplomatic and economic aspects of

the Act East Policy are the subject of many studies, whereas, India and its naval modernisation of maritime security initiatives are studied individually. This disintegrated method has led to failure of integrated analysis that looks at the support, complementation or limitation of the objectives of the Act East Policy by the maritime strategy.

Moreover, the qualitative research that is a systematic analysis of the policy coherence between the Indian foreign policy ambitions and the sea power capabilities in the long term is also limited.

Consequently, the policy intent-operational practice alignment has not been fully explored, especially in the light of the changing Indo-Pacific geopolitics

Research Objective

This research will be critical in the study of the Act East Policy and the India maritime strategy over the period of 2014-2025 and their subsequent alignment and effectiveness in strategy

The objectives of the research are:

- I. To analyze the development of the Act East Policy in India since the year 2014.
- II. To examine India as a maritime strategy in the Indo-Pacific structure.
- III. To measure the extent of strategic alignment between the policy objectives and maritime practices.
- IV. To establish the strategic challenges, constraints, and limitations in influencing the strategic ambitions of India

Research Questions

1. What has been the development of the Act East Policy of India since its establishment, and how does India strategically change?
2. How does the policy of India's Act East Policy affect diplomatic, economic, and defense matters of the country in relation to major Indo-Pacific nations, and Southeast Asia in particular?
3. What is the relationship between the Act East Policy and India's Maritime Strategy with regards to Indo-Pacific region?
4. How far have India's Act East Policy been effective in countering the increasing presence of China in the Indo-Pacific region?

Hypothesis

1. India's Act East Policy between 2014 and 2025 lead to the convergence of strategic maritime interests, economic connectivity imperatives, and the growing assertiveness of a dominant regional power transformed India's engagement in the Indo-Pacific
2. India's maritime strategy shifted from a reactive, continental-focused posture to a proactive, blue-water power projection orientation anchored in multilateral institutional framework
3. India's Act East Policy (2014–2025) did not fundamentally alter its maritime strategic posture in the Indo-Pacific; instead, rhetorical escalation masked an underlying continuity of cautious, hedge-based foreign policy, constrained by domestic capability deficits and the enduring logic of strategic autonomy

Significance

The relevance of this project is three. To begin with, the study offers scholars of Indo-Pacific security studies and Indian foreign policy a comparatively integrated empirical foundation that would combine the economic, infrastructural, and military-maritime strands to a unitary level. Although most studies analyze economic connectivity, port infrastructure and maritime security separately, this paper is an attempt to put the three on a similar level of analysis. Second, to policy practitioners, both those in the Ministry of External Affairs/Ministry of Defence and those in oil maritime and infrastructure agencies, the study provides an insight into how the maritime policy of India has developed and, therefore things that may need to be reformed or recalibrated. Third, within an Indo-Pacific maritime order that is rapidly changing, the paper provides evidence of the consistency and sustainability of Indian maritime turn: Are India maritime ambitions well served by instruments and institutions? Has the danger of dissonance between economic connectivity programmes and strategic maritime partnerships occurred?

Theoretical and Analytical Framework

Neo-Realism and Geopolitical drivers

The first interpretation of the maritime transformation in India is the neo-realism interpretation that the anarchic nature of the international system forces the states to seek relative gains and behaviour of self-help. The distribution of power which occurred after 1991 and was characterized by the emergence of China and the decentralization of the maritime competition throughout the

Indo-Pacific led to the establishment of a set of security externalities that motivated India to extend its own maritime presence (Mearsheimer, 2001; Waltz, 1979). The Indian Ocean, which is traditionally seen as the backyard of India, turned into the field of great-power politics of the United States, Japan, Australia and more through its Maritime Silk Road and dual-use port infrastructure (Khurana, 2008; Brewster, 2014).

In this regard, the actions of India that started with naval modernization to multilateral coordination are indicators of realist balancing and hedging. Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (QUAD), Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI), and joint exercises like Malabar are the strategic initiatives that balance without the commitment of alliance (Rehman, 2020; Tellis, 2017). India prefers autonomy-enhancing multilateralism, whereby participation in the major powers is moderated by non-alignment instincts, is also explained by neo-realism (Pant and Supaat, 2015). In this context, China is creating security dilemmas in the South China Sea due to its naval modernization and assertiveness in the region, which spill over into the Bay of Bengal and the Indian Ocean Region (IOR) as its extension. India trying to get sea lanes, build Maritime Domain Awareness (MDA) and enhance forward presence thereby reflective of realist logic, in that India aims at deterring, denying and creating a situational understanding over a wider maritime area (Indian Navy, 2015; Scott, 2012).

Liberal Institutionalism and Regional Order

To supplement realism, liberal institutionalism theorizes why India has invested concurrently in multilateral institutions and cooperative rule-making. According to the liberal perspective, institutions alleviate uncertainty, enhance information sharing and lower the cost of transactions among states (Keohane, 1984; Nye, 2011). The involvement of India in the ASEAN organized frameworks of East Asia Summit, ASEAN Defence Ministers Meeting Plus and the ASEAN Regional Forum is an example of how the institute participation improves the transparency and predictability in maritime behavior (Acharya, 2014).

On a regional level, India is a leader in the Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA) and Indian Ocean Naval Symposium (IONS) to demonstrate a cooperative security ethos based on capacity-building, human-assistance-disaster-recovery, and non-conventional security threats like piracy and climate risk (Gill, 2019; Brewster, 2012). The establishment of IFC-IOR (Information Fusion

Centre) and regional linkages to facilitate data sharing in shipping movements also explains the establishment of collective security through the transparency of information through liberal institutionalism.

Maritime diplomacy India will be part of the rules-based Indo-Pacific order of this paradigm, which favors the norms of UNCLOS, freedom of navigation, and peaceful resolution of conflicts (Krishnan, 2015; Permanent Court of Arbitration, 2014). Although the working groups on critical technologies, climate, and maritime domain awareness at the QUAD can be viewed through the prism of realist competition, they represent liberal modes of cooperation that can result in interdependence and alleviate the risk of misunderstanding. India, therefore, and its dual alignment as strategic deterrence with multilateralism as co-operation, unveils the presence of realist imperative and liberal functionalism in India as a maritime state.

Grand-Strategic Synthesis: Sea Power, Geo-Economics, and State Capacity

The third strand places the maritime policy of India in a grand-strategic synthesis that incorporates the sea-power theory, geo-economics and domestic state capacity. Using the classic thesis of Mahan (1890) that the possessing of sea lines is the key to prosperity and influence, the maritime posture of India is becoming directly connected to the projection of the naval power and building up of infrastructure as well as the industrial policy. These scholars, including Brewster (2014) and Medcalf (2020), remark that the grand strategy of India has changed to be based on the concept of maritime activism as it links the Indian Ocean to the Western Pacific via connectivity corridors and naval diplomacy.

This combination of hard and soft instruments includes the protection of Sea Lines of Communication (SLOCs), port-led efforts such as Sagarmala, and blue-economy strategies within the context of SAGAR (Security and Growth for All in the Region). According to neo-Mahanian explanations, India utilizes maritime infrastructures to enhance geo-economic capabilities, where port building and logistics chains are the instruments of encouraging domestic industrial competitiveness and regional influence (Gupta, 2020; Chandra and Ghosh, 2019).

The effectiveness of this synthesis on the domestic level is determined by state capacity, the capacity of the bureaucratic and industrial forces to carry out complex maritime projects. The

Maritime India Vision 2030 (MoPSW, 2021) is one such example of trying to put strategy into practice in the form of infrastructure pipelines. However, analysts warn, strategic coherence can be watered down by fragmented governance, shipbuilding restrictions, and a lack of technological self-reliance (Tellis, 2017; Rehman, 2020). Therefore, the grand-strategic framework sheds light on the ambition and asymmetry: maritime development in India can be viewed as the desire of a middle power that makes use of the geography and trade, yet it is still determined by domestic strengths.

Policy-Process Framework: From Agenda Setting to Feedback

This paper also uses policy-process lens to relate systemic theories to operational policy making; agenda setting, policy tools, implementation as well as feedback loop (Howlett and Ramesh, 2003). The 26/11 attacks in Mumbai gave a conclusive agenda setting moment and made maritime security a core policy agenda rather than a peripheral one (Gill, 2019). Over the next decade, numerous policy tools were developed, including coastal security architecture (NC3I, IMAC, IFC-IOR) as well as economic and strategic ones, such as Sagarmala (2015), SAGAR (2015), and IPOI (2019).

The analysis of the implementation shows that maritime governance in India is multi-actor, with ministries, naval and coast-guard organizations, state governments, and the port operators in the private sector as actors. The policy streams have their own goals: Sagarmala is trying to achieve the efficiency of logistics and industrial corridors; SAGAR embodies the regional maritime diplomacy; IPOI promotes the rule-based cooperation; IFC-IOR implements information fusion. Combining these tools, a policy ecosystem bridging development and security is created (NITI Aayog, 2021).

Initiative/Policy Instrument	Key Goals & Objectives	Primary Actors/Stakeholders	Implementation Constraints
Maritime India Vision (MIV) 2030	Transform Indian maritime sector, achieve top 10 shipbuilding ranking, boost	Ministry of Ports, Shipping & Waterways (MoPSW), State Maritime Boards, Port Authorities.	High capital requirement, technological gaps, coordination between central/state agencies.

	cruise tourism & green ports.		
Sagarmala Programme	Port-led development, port-rail/road connectivity, coastal community development, digitization.	Sagarmala Development Company Ltd (SDCL), Port Trusts, Rail Vikas Nigam Ltd.	Land acquisition issues, environmental clearances, logistical integration bottlenecks.
Green Maritime Sector Initiative (MIV 2030)	Reduce emissions, adopt renewable energy (solar/wind), "Zero Accident" safety program.	Major Ports, International Maritime Organization (IMO) (standards), Shipping Corporation of India.	High cost of green technology adoption, lack of infrastructure for alternative fuels.
National Logistics Portal (Marine)	Create a single-window digital platform for stakeholders to reduce transaction time and costs.	Ministry of Commerce, Port Authorities, Custom Brokers, Shippers.	Data integration across multiple stakeholders, cybersecurity concerns.
<u>Coastal Shipping Development</u>	Increase modal share of coastal shipping for freight to reduce logistics costs.	Directorate General of Shipping, Logistics Companies.	Shortage of coastal vessels, high operational costs, underdeveloped coastal infrastructure.

New Legal Framework (Draft Merchant Shipping Act 2025)	Modernize maritime laws to ensure safety, security, and promote investment.	Parliament, Ministry of Law and Justice, Shipping Ministry.	Need to balance environmental safety with economic growth, regulatory alignment.
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Research Methodology

The study has a qualitative, descriptive, and analytical research design, given that it involves the systematic review of available texts. Secondary research design has been used because the study will use already published materials instead of producing primary data (interviews, surveys, and fieldwork). The design fits best the policy-oriented research that aims at examining the macro- level strategic trends and state accounts during a long time

The descriptive factor of the research design allows the research to trace the development of the Act East Policy and India maritime strategy between 2014 and 2025. The analytical element is more than description because it evaluates critically the congruence of the policy goals and strategic practices. Combining these methods, the work has a contextual background and a critical analysis, thus making it scholarly and analytically sound

Data Collection

Primary Sources

The current study will use two methods to gather primary data: structured questionnaires and semi-structured interviews. The questionnaires will measure the opinions and impressions about the goals of the Act East Policy, its success, and its implications for strategy with respect to India's maritime strategy over the time frame of 2014 through 2025. The individuals responding to the questionnaires will be made up of those in academia, research, and analysis related to strategy, maritime subjects, and defense, as well as others with knowledge and professional experience related to international relations, foreign policy, and maritime security. The questionnaire will be based primarily on the Likert scale, whereby respondents can

indicate their level of agreement or disagreement with several statements related to the focus of this research. In addition to the questionnaires, the study will gather qualitative data through expert interviews of individuals in an effort to gain rich, qualitative insights into topics such as India's maritime cooperation with ASEAN countries, the establishment of strategic alliances in the Indo-Pacific region, and the challenges facing the Act East Policy implementation. The study anticipates gathering data from approximately 80-120 respondents via the purposive sampling technique, which allows the researcher to identify respondents who have the requisite knowledge and experience needed to be able to respond to the subject of this study.

Secondary Sources

To get breadth, depth and credibility, the data used in this study is obtained using a broad selection of secondary qualitative data. The most common categories of sources are: Policy documents by the government including foreign policy statements, maritime policies and official frameworks on how India will interact with the region. White papers on defence and doctrines on maritime which give clues to the Indian strategic thinking, maritime priorities and maritime security objectives. Theoretical insights and critical evaluations of the India foreign and maritime policies available in academic journals and scholarly books. Think tank reports especially of organizations like the Observer Research Foundation (ORF), Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses (IDSA) and the International Institute of Strategic Studies (IISS), which offer a skilled estimation and policy pertinent examination.

Political speeches and official declarations issued between 2014 and 2025 that represent the changing strategic discourses and priorities in policy formulation. Relevance, credibility, and academic reliability are the criteria used in the selection of the sources. Peer reviewed literature and official policy documents are given an emphasis to make the data base sound.

Data Analysis Method

The thematic analysis is the main qualitative data analysis tool used in the study. Thematic analysis can be considered appropriate to detect, analyse and comprehend common patterns and themes of various textual materials. The themes of this study are developed by the close reading and systematic comparison of documents without any software and automated tools.

The major themes of analysis are maritime security, diplomatic relations, power projection,

regional alliances and strategic alignment. The analysis is structured using these themes and how the maritime strategy of India is aiding the goals of the Act East Policy. The lack of coding software has no negative implications on the analytical rigour since the analysis was performed through meticulous manual categorisation and interpretive argument, which is in line with the qualitative research approach in policy research

The purpose of such a choice is to justify Secondary Qualitative Research.

Secondary qualitative research is reasonable to use on a number of reasons. To begin with, the research is practical and feasible because it is based on authoritative and easy to access sources. Second, the use of official documents, scholarly literature and expert reports can offer a credible foundation of the analysis of policy development and strategic purpose over time. Third, policy analysis, in particular, is well served by qualitative secondary research, in which it is more vital to comprehend discourse, strategy, and institutional views than quantifiable results. Also, secondary research is particularly fitting because the study has a long time span (2014-2025), which gives the opportunity to track the policy changes and strategic directions over the years and have no limitations associated with collecting primary data.

Proposed chapters

Chapter No.	Chapter Title	Core Focus	Key Themes / Subtopics
Chapter 1	Introduction, Conceptual Framework & Research Design	Establish theoretical and methodological foundation	Background (Look East → Act East); Research problem & questions; Hypotheses; Theoretical frameworks (Realism, Sea Power Theory, Middle Power Diplomacy); Methodology; Scope & limitations
Chapter 2	Evolution of India's Act East Policy (2014-2025)	Diplomatic and geopolitical transformation	Transition from Look East to Act East; Indo-Pacific articulation; ASEAN engagement; Connectivity projects (IMT Highway, Kaladan); Strategic convergence with Quad

Chapter 3	India's Maritime Doctrine and Strategic Vision	Doctrinal and conceptual maritime foundations	SAGAR (2015); Indian Maritime Security Strategy (2015/16); Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative; Maritime zones of interest; Blue Economy
Chapter 4	Naval Modernization and Maritime Capacity (2014–2025)	Hard power capabilities	INS Vikrant; Submarine programs; Andaman & Nicobar Command; Logistics agreements (LEMOA, COMCASA, BECA); Maritime domain awareness; Naval exercises
Chapter 5	Strategic Partnerships and Indo-Pacific Balancing	External alignment and coalition-building	Quad revival; India–ASEAN maritime ties; Japan & Australia partnerships; Island diplomacy; Competition with China's BRI
Chapter 6	Conclusion	Critical evaluation and policy direction	Resource constraints; Implementation delays; China's maritime footprint; Industrial capacity; Strategic autonomy; Future policy recommendations

Timeline (Indicative)

Semester	Duration	Research Activities	Expected Output
Semester 1	Months 1–6	Coursework (Research Methodology, IR Theory, Research Ethics); Topic finalization; Preliminary literature review; Identification of research gap; Development of research questions and objectives	Research framework and initial literature review
Semester 2	Months 7–12	Detailed literature review; Development of theoretical framework (Realism, Sea Power Theory, Middle Power Diplomacy); Research methodology design; Drafting of synopsis; RDC/DRC presentation	Approved PhD synopsis
Semester 3	Months 13–18	Data collection and policy document analysis; Writing Chapter 1 and writing Chapter 2	Draft of Chapters 1 and 2
Semester 4	Months 19–24	Research on maritime strategy and doctrine; Writing Chapter 3	Completed Chapter 3
Semester 5	Months 25–30	Research on naval capabilities and strategic partnerships; Writing Chapter 4 and Chapter 5	Completed Chapters 4 and 5
Semester 6	Months 31–36	Writing Chapter 6	Final PhD thesis submission

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